

THE TANK — Pitch Report

PlacePrep AI

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Indian engineering and computer science students preparing for software placements use many scattered resources but often don't know what to study next, which skills are weak, or whether they are actually placement-ready.

SOLUTION

PlacePrep AI is an AI-powered placement coach that assesses a student's skills, identifies weak areas, creates a personalized preparation roadmap, assigns daily tasks, and tracks placement readiness over time.

REVENUE MODEL

Freemium SaaS model. Students get a free diagnostic assessment and initial roadmap. Premium plans provide daily personalized tracking, readiness score updates, advanced preparation plans, and future AI mock interviews.

TARGET AUDIENCE

Indian engineering and computer science students aged 18–24, especially 2nd, 3rd, and 4th year students preparing for software internships and campus placements.

FUNDING ASK

\$100,000 for 10% equity

Scorecard

Market Potential: 59 / 100

Innovation: 56 / 100

Business Model: 60 / 100

Execution: 56 / 100

Investment Worthiness: 67 / 100

Overall Investment Score: 60 / 100

The Verdict

COME BACK LATER — Promising, but the sharks need more proof before they commit capital.

Suggested Valuation: \$1,000,000

Funding Offered: \$0 for 10.0% equity

Judge Reasoning

THE VENTURE CAPITALIST

Market Potential was decent (59/100), enough to keep me listening, not enough to fully commit alone.

THE FOUNDER

Execution was decent (56/100), enough to keep me listening, not enough to fully commit alone.

THE CUSTOMER

Innovation was decent (56/100), enough to keep me listening, not enough to fully commit alone.

THE ANGEL INVESTOR

Business Model was decent (60/100), enough to keep me listening, not enough to fully commit alone.

Q&A Transcript

THE VENTURE CAPITALIST ASKED:

How big is the total market for Indian engineering and computer science students aged 18–24, especially 2nd, 3rd, and 4th year students preparing for software internships and campus placements., and what stops a well-funded competitor from crushing PlacePrep AI in 18 months?

YOU ANSWERED:

The market is large enough to build a meaningful business, but I wouldn't claim the entire engineering market as our initial target. We're starting with 2nd–4th year engineering and computer science students actively preparing for software internships and campus placements.

The bigger threat is competition. A well-funded competitor could copy basic AI assessment and roadmap features quickly. Our defense is focused execution, persistent student progress data, campus distribution, strong feedback loops, and eventually partnerships with colleges and student communities.

I'm not relying on a feature moat. I'm relying on execution, distribution, and proving that students repeatedly use PlacePrep AI and get better placement outcomes.

THE VENTURE CAPITALIST ASKED:

If I gave you 10x the funding ask today, what specifically would scale — and what would break?

YOU ANSWERED:

With 10x the funding, I would scale three areas: product development, customer acquisition, and campus distribution. We would improve the personalized assessment and roadmap engine, strengthen progress tracking and AI mock interviews, and build partnerships with colleges, coding clubs, and student communities.

What could break is execution and retention. If we acquire students faster than we can prove they consistently use the product, we could burn capital without creating lasting value. We would therefore scale in stages, measuring activation, Day-7 retention, task completion, and conversion before increasing spending significantly.

The biggest constraint isn't technology — it's proving that students will consistently use and pay for PlacePrep AI. I would use the additional funding to accelerate that validation rather than simply spend it faster.

THE FOUNDER ASKED:

Walk me through what you've actually shipped so far. What's built, and what's still a slide?

YOU ANSWERED:

So far, I've shipped the validation and MVP design rather than a production-ready platform. I've completed the customer and market validation work, defined the ICP and buyer persona, mapped the customer journey and pain points, and designed the focused MVP around four core features: a diagnostic assessment, an AI-generated personalized roadmap, daily tasks, and progress tracking.

What's built: the product concept, validation framework, customer journey, and focused MVP specification.

What's still a slide: the production-ready AI platform, real student users, paying customers, proven retention, and verified revenue.

My next priority is to build the narrow MVP and test it with 20–50 real students before investing heavily in additional features.

THE FOUNDER ASKED:

What's the single biggest execution risk that could kill PlacePrep AI, and what have you already done about it?

YOU ANSWERED:

The single biggest execution risk is building a product that students don't consistently use. Students already have many free resources, so simply creating another placement-preparation platform won't be enough.

What I've already done is narrow the MVP around the core problem of prioritization and accountability instead of trying to build a complete learning platform. I've defined the ICP, buyer persona, customer journey, pain points, and a focused MVP with four core features: a diagnostic assessment, personalized AI roadmap, daily tasks, and progress tracking.

The next step is to validate this with 20–50 real students and measure activation, Day-7 retention, task completion, and willingness to pay. If those signals are weak, I'll pivot before investing heavily in additional features.

THE CUSTOMER ASKED:

Why would Indian engineering and computer science students aged 18–24, especially 2nd, 3rd, and 4th year students preparing for software internships and campus placements, choose this over doing nothing, or over a spreadsheet and some willpower?

YOU ANSWERED:

The problem isn't a lack of resources — it's knowing what to do with them. Students already have LeetCode, GeeksforGeeks, YouTube, and AI tools, but they can still spend months preparing without knowing whether they're focusing on the right skills or whether they're actually placement-ready.

PlacePrep AI turns that scattered effort into a personalized system. A student takes a diagnostic assessment, gets a roadmap based on their weaknesses and target role, receives daily tasks, and tracks their progress and readiness over time.

A spreadsheet can track tasks, but it can't diagnose skill gaps, personalize the preparation plan, or continuously adapt it. PlacePrep AI's value is reducing uncertainty and turning preparation into a clear daily workflow.

I haven't proven this advantage with real users yet. That's why the MVP will test whether students actually use the system repeatedly and whether it improves their preparation outcomes.

THE CUSTOMER ASKED:

What's the one feature people actually use every week — not the one on your roadmap slide?

YOU ANSWERED:

The feature I expect students to use every week is the personalized daily preparation plan. It turns their assessment results into specific tasks based on their weak areas and placement goals.

The goal isn't just to give students another list of resources. It's to answer the question, "What should I work on today?" and let them track whether they completed it.

I haven't validated this with real users yet, so this is still a hypothesis. The MVP will measure weekly usage, task completion, and Day-7 retention to determine whether this actually becomes a recurring habit.

THE ANGEL INVESTOR ASKED:

Walk me through the unit economics — what does it cost you to acquire a customer, and what do they pay you back over time?

YOU ANSWERED:

We don't have validated CAC or LTV yet because PlacePrep AI is still at the MVP-validation stage. I would rather be transparent about that than present hypothetical unit economics as proven.

Our initial acquisition strategy is to use low-cost channels such as campus communities, coding clubs, student creators, referrals, and organic content rather than relying heavily on paid advertising. This should help keep early CAC low, but we need real acquisition data to confirm it.

On the revenue side, we're testing a ₹199–₹299 monthly plan or a ₹99 free diagnostic assessment and initial roadmap as the acquisition funnel.

Our first 50–100 users will help us measure CAC, free-to-paid conversion, retention, and revenue per customer. Once we have those numbers, we'll calculate LTV and determine whether the economics support scaling.

So today, the unit economics are a hypothesis, not a proven advantage. The immediate goal is to prove that a student we acquire cheaply will stay long enough and pay enough to make the model sustainable.

THE ANGEL INVESTOR ASKED:

At what point does this business become profitable without needing another check from someone like me?

YOU ANSWERED:

I would define profitability as the point where recurring subscription revenue covers our product, AI infrastructure, support, and customer acquisition costs without relying on outside funding.

Our current hypothesis is around 1,000 paying students at an average generate about ₹2.5 lakh in monthly recurring revenue. If our operating lean, that gives us a path toward sustainable profitability.

But I haven't validated that threshold yet because we don't have real CAC, retention, or infrastructure-cost data. My plan is to use the first 50–100 users to establish those numbers and calculate the actual break-even point.

The goal isn't to raise another round to cover an unproven model. It's to prove that the core subscription business can become self-sustaining before scaling aggressively.